



TIPS FOR CAREGIVERS

When you are caring for your child, whether in the hospital or at home, caring for yourself is often your last priority. However, it is important to create a balance between caring for others and yourself. You may not feel that caring for yourself is a priority, but it is imperative that you try. The best gift you can give your loved one is to also care for yourself. Below are some tips on how to deal with the stress and anxiety that accompanies caring for a child with Congenital Heart Disease.

- **Ask for and accept help**
 - Acknowledging that you need help can be just as difficult as accepting it. However, helping you in both big and small ways is a great opportunity for your family and friends to feel like they are supporting you during this stressful time. Make a list of things that need to be done to keep your life running, and be realistic about what you have the time and energy to accomplish. Keep the list handy and next time a friend or family member asks, let them know what they could do to help. Family and friends are often happy to help with child care, collecting your mail, mowing your grass, grocery shopping, meal planning or taking you out for a meal for a break.
- **Give yourself a break, literally and figuratively**
 - No one expects you to have all the answers or solve all of the challenges currently facing your family. Please give yourself a break! Accept that being your child's parent means sometimes you will have to rely on others for information and assistance while you focus on being your child's best advocate and caregiver. While you are at it, take a break from care giving once in a while too! It is essential to schedule time away from the dual responsibilities of parenting and care giving for your own mental health. Make plans for a friend, family member or health care provider to spend time with your child while you spend time away. Read a book, go shopping, nap – choose something that allows you to relax.
- **Connect – with your care team, your support network and other families**
 - Being the caregiver of a child with medical needs can be an isolating experience. It is important that you reach out and connect with people who can help you navigate your child's health care needs and help you feel less alone on the journey. Ask your medical provider or social worker for referrals to community support groups and to put you in touch with another family who has experienced a similar situation. Use the internet to keep your distant family and friends updated on your child's condition and plan of care. Utilize the support services that your hospital offers such as social work services, child life, pastoral care or parent navigators.
- **Eat and drink regularly**
 - Living on coffee and food from a hospital cafeteria is no way to treat your body and it won't give you the energy you need to continue to be your child's advocate. It is important that you eat nutritiously and drink plenty of water during hospitalization. Although it is easy to lose track of time and miss important meals when you are on "hospital time", combat this by keeping snacks such as granola bars, fruit or nuts with you.
- **Exercise**
 - Whether your child is in the hospital or at home, regular exercise is important to both your physical and emotional well being. Try to schedule at least twenty minutes of exercise a day – even a brisk walk around the hospital counts! Studies have shown that regular exercise clears the mind, encourages better sleep and is a great stress reducer.

- **Distraction, Distraction, Distraction**
 - Keeping up with favorite hobbies or developing a new one is a good way to take a mental vacation. Knitting, reading, drawing, blogging are easy ways to busy your hands and quiet your mind.
- **Take care of your own health**
 - When you are caring for your child, your health becomes secondary. However, if you aren't healthy meeting your child's needs will be more difficult. Get a yearly flu shot and make the time to see your physician regularly. If you have recently given birth, it is important to follow your physician's recommendations regarding activity restrictions and keep your follow up appointments. Pay attention to your emotional state as well and contact your physician or social worker if you are concerned about depression.
- **Get organized**
 - Keep all of the information you've received regarding your child's diagnosis safely in one place. If your hospital doesn't provide a notebook to organize your child's medical information, purchase one yourself. A binder makes it possible to keep medication schedules, discharge instructions, clinic letters, important phone numbers and insurance information organized and portable.
- **Educate yourself**
 - Knowledge is power so arm yourself with appropriate information about your child's diagnosis, medication and treatment plan. If your hospital allows, participate in medical rounds on your child. Request family meetings for updates or to discuss care plan changes. Keep a notebook nearby and write down questions as you think of them. Ask your physician, social worker or child life specialist for referrals to trusted websites and other resources. Avoid "internet overload" by sticking to reputable websites.
- **Take back your family**
 - Don't let your child's diagnosis define your family. Recognize that your child's illness places all members of the family under increased stress and makes it more difficult for you to support each other. This is especially true for other children in the family who may have fears and anxiety that they aren't voicing. It is important that your family spend time together that is not focused on your child's diagnosis. Plan family game nights, special meals or attend a sporting event as a family or as a special treat for siblings.